Disneyland

By Laurie Notaro

INTRODUCTION

According to literally everybody on planet Earth, it's impossible for a person to make it to 30+ years of age without ever having been to the most magical place on Earth.

In fact, whenever you tell a person you've never been to Disneyland, they go through at least seven different stages of stunning disbelief before telling you that you have to — no, listen: YOU. HAVE. TO. — get in a car and drive to Disneyland immediately.

Hours later, you find yourself in a car bound for the magical land of Disney, and there's no going back. You're going to Disneyland for the first time, as a grown adult, and there's nothing you can do about it.

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LAURIE: **(Pg 133-151)** Everywhere we went in Disneyland at least two out of five kids were sobbing, screaming, or hyperventilating, having either been recently smacked, recently yelled at, or recently threatened with being "sent back to the room."

I, however, was having a grand time. Somehow, either I had arrived on the perfect day or I had traveled through some sort of self-esteem time warp, but I was one of the prettiest people at Disneyland. Now, honestly, that's not saying much about me, but I will admit that every time I saw two honey-baked hams swinging out the armholes of a tank top, my self-esteem skyrocketed. A size sixteen anywhere else in the free world translated to a size four here, and I never felt so liberated.

I loved Disneyland. I LOVED IT. I had no idea I was going to have such a good time when my sister had asked me to accompany her and my nephew Nicholas to celebrate his fourth birthday. I mean, it's Disneyland, and it has very little appeal for a childless woman in her thirties, unless her intelligence level is significantly below average. I agreed to go on this trip for two reasons:

1. I try really hard to be the cool aunt . . . going on this trip would give me the opportunity

to have fun with my nephew, bond even closer with him, and build his trust in me so that I might wield him like a puppet and mold him into the child I absolutely knew we both wanted him to be.

2. I was also at Disneyland paying penance for "embarrassing and traumatizing him in front of twenty of his little friends," as a helper in Nicholas's preschool classroom for the Harvest Festival or, what they used to call in less stringently politically correct days of yore, Halloween.

Now, I will admit that perhaps I had some responsibility in the matter, but what unfolded that afternoon was in no way entirely my fault . . .

After the teacher introduced me as Nicholas's Aunt Laurie, she assigned me to the spider-web table, where I was supposed to help little kids make a spider web on a piece of paper with glue and string. And that was all going fine until the first little girl I was supposed to help, Angelina-Charlize, didn't want to make a spider web, she just wanted to write her name. I was cool with that. That was fine. No skin off my nose. Go ahead and write your name, you know? So Angelina-Charlize wrote her name, complete with a backward r. In an attempt at helping, I told her that we should try turning the r around a bit, and that's when she openly mocked me.

ANGELINA-CHARLIZE: *(chanting)* Aunt Gloria doesn't know how to make an "r" . . . That's so sad for a grown-up.

LAURIE: No, really, the r needs to face the other way -- Would you like me to show you?

ANGELINA-CHARLIZE: There's an r in my name, so I should know. Aunt Gloria can't make an r, Aunt Gloria can't make an r!

LAURIE: Actually, it's Aunt Laurie, and I've been writing for a long time, so maybe I should know.

ANGELINA-CHARLIZE: If you know, then why can't you make one? Because you can't! You can't you can't you caaaan't!"

LAURIE: "You know," I wanted so desperately to tell them, "you girls keep writing in your little

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chimpy hieroglyphics that only a mirror can read and I'll be more than happy to write you a recommendation to Klown Kollege when the time comes, because you will indeed need it."

Instead, I just smiled and said: March to your own dyslexic drum, Angelina Calista Jennifer Aniston Lopez Drew Barrymore. I just really hope you like the circus.

That was pretty much the moment that Nicholas's teacher came over, leaned into my ear and whispered, "Maybe we should try the play area, where it's not so structured."

I had been fired from the spider web table. I had just totally gotten fired from the spider web table, and unjustly so!

Whatever, I said to myself, I'll show them what I can do in the play area, I'll show them. Much to my relief, I saw my nephew in the play area, running what appeared to be an invisible grocery store, using his creative imagination, just like his Aunt Laurie had taught him.

NICOLAS: And there you go. *[Nicholas said to another little boy as he handed him a big fistful of air.]*

LAURIE: Hello, sir. I would like an apple. Do you sell apples, Nicholas?"

NICOLAS: Yes, I do," *[handing me absolutely nothing]* And my name is Mr. Booley when I'm at my store . . . It's forty dollars, please.

LAURIE: Well, that's a little steep, don't you think? Safeway has apples for ninety-nine cents a pound, and I can actually see those!"

NICOLAS: Well, then, maybe you should go to Safeway.

LAURIE: Okay, okay, I get it [putting out my hand with nothing in it.] Here's your forty dollars.

NICOLAS: *[Scoffing]* My store only takes credit cards.

LAURIE: Did he give you a credit card? *[pointing to the customer before me]*

NICOLAS: He's a little boy, Aunt Gloria. He doesn't have credit cards. Are any of your credit cards still good?"

LAURIE: I think maybe you've been talking to Grandma about my credit status, but let me assure you that it is almost cleared up now. Maybe I will go to Safeway! And you know my

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name is Aunt Laurie!"

NICOLAS: *[yelling and pointing]* Aunt Gloria shoplifted! She shoplifted my apple!

LAURIE: I did not! And his prices are highway robbery! Would you pay forty bucks for an apple? Plus twenty-one percent interest? . . . Wait . . .There is no apple! *[showing everyone empty, appleless hands]* You can't steal something that doesn't exist! There is no apple!"

OTHER CHILD: I saw her take a banana, too!

LAURIE: So that was why I was at Disneyland. I thought it would make up for the alleged, imaginary fruit thievery incident.

Now, I was at the "Character Breakfast" in Goofy's Kitchen ($35 to have the Mad Hatter hop around your table like a flea as you're trying to eat your Mickey Mouse waffles).

MAD HATTER: Hey, how are those waffles? They should make Mad Hatter waffles! Mad Hatter waffles! Waffles with a big hat! Those are the kind of waffles I'd eat!"

LAURIE: You know, we could have grabbed a bagel outside for two bucks, but then the delight of having a neurotic midget dressed as Oscar Wilde buzz around us like a palmetto roach would have been lost forever.

NICOLAS: *[squealing]* Goofy! Goofy!! Over here, Goofy, over here! It's my birthday!

LAURIE: I turned around, and there he was; that giant dog thing or walrus or whatever he is suddenly appeared, pulling the little children toward him like safety pins to a magnet.

MAD HATTER: It's my un-birthday! Come to *my* tea party!"

NICOLAS: "I love Goofy!" *[hugging Goofy]*

MAD HATTAR: Goofy thinks he's all that, but he's not. You'll hug Goofy but you won't hug me. But let me tell you something, Goofy is not as hot as he thinks he is. Are you, Goofy? Are you?"

LAURIE: And then, as I turned to look at Goofy and Nicholas, Goofy's middle finger-and I mean there was no mistaking it, since he only has three of them-was vividly scratching his nose. Goofy flipping off the Mad Hatter? That is the coolest thing I've ever seen. I'd totally give them both fifty bucks to fight.

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NICOLAS: I love Gadget's Go Coaster! You'll ride, too, won't you, Aunt Laurie?

LAURIE: Of course. It's your birthday, how could I not? *(to audience)* The whole ride, which was a basic, no-frills kiddie roller coaster sporting props of oversize combs, and a couple rather large stationary frogs, lasted no more than a minute, so when the train pulled to the boarding platform at the end, Nicholas said he wanted to go again.

Before I could even say anything, the train took off and I was trying to concentrate on his fun when we turned a bend in the ride, and then suddenly out of nowhere, something hard and fast struck me in the side of the head. I grabbed my skull, which was now wet with a liquid I was really hoping was not a body fluid, like blood, and that's when I saw it -- a seemingly placid, peaceful, unaggressive frog statue until it decided to spit at you with a fire hose of water that was conveniently hidden from view. I was still trying to wipe the water from my face when we pulled into the boarding station next to an empty platform.

CONDUCTOR: Wanna go again?

LAURIE: And the conductor took off for our next round without even stopping. *(to conductor)* Hey! I'm done with this ride! Aunt Laurie is done!

PPPLLLLTTT!! went the frog as I passed him again, hard and fast like the first time and just as wet. And there I was, there I was, a wet, childless woman in her thirties, trying to wipe water out of her eyes, one side of her head dripping with frog spit, as she went around and around and around the Go Coaster. Finally, THANK GOD, someone was on the platform when we came around the last time.

[to Nicholas] The frog on your ride hocked on me, you know, and wrecked my pretty supermodel hair. And I think it also left a hematoma where the spray hit me in the head. It's all soft and squishy in that spot now."

NICOLAS: Gadget's Go Coaster made me ready for Splash Mountain! Can we go?

LAURIE: Oh, come on, dude! *[stomping my foot]* I already look like a sponge! Splash Mountain? Let's go back to the hotel and eat room service stuff, okay? Eighteen-dollar grilled cheese sandwiches!

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NICOLAS: *[shaking his head]* Splash Mountain!

LAURIE: Okay, fine. I am here to pay for my sins. Before I knew it, I was hustled into a log, sitting in the second seat behind one of the almost teenage sons of the guy ahead of us in line. He looked at the wet side of my head and gave me a pained smile.

(to pre-teen) I know you were hoping to be straddled by a skinny blonde cheerleader with perfect skin and a Crest Nighttime Whitening Strips smile. But an hour ago, I was the hottest chick in this park.

He grimaced visibly and moved forward on the log before we lurched and then took off. I heard my nephew squeal with anticipation directly behind me. We reached the top, paused for a moment, and then dropped furiously downward, and that's when I gasped.

Because that's when it hit me: When you're about to dive into a pool of water from four stories up going roughly 30 to 40 miles per hour and you're wearing a white T-shirt with a white nylon bra underneath it, there's a very good reason to try to get the hell out of that car. A very good reason.

NICOLAS: Why are your arms crossed? Are you mad?

LAURIE: I'm not sure if 'mad' is the word, Nicholas. I'm just trying to keep our little trip here at a G rating. If I uncross my arms, either I'd get taken away by or I'd pop up in the latest version of Totally Ugly Girls Gone Wild. I started out so great this morning, and now I look like a used Bounty paper towel.

NICHOLAS: Let's go to Tom Sawyer Island!"

LAURIE: Fine with Aunt Laurie. She needs to find some sun before she gets nominated for adult entertainer of the year.

Over on the island, I tried my best to keep up, but I lost [him] in the labyrinth of Injun Joe's Cave, being that I couldn't move very freely without exposing myself to a random child. In favor of keeping my balance and remaining upright, I decided to try and backtrack my way out and then find a nice sunny spot where I could dry out and enjoy the benefits of opaque

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clothing again. Finally, I saw the opening of the cave and headed toward it, and as I entered daylight, I suddenly saw the tumble of sky, the sun, glimpses of blurry faces, and finally, a big patch of brown all tossed in front of me like a salad.

When I looked up, I heard a chorus of tiny giggles and saw a bunch of rotten kids above me on the mountain, peering over and cackling like Children of the Corn. I had totally eaten it on Tom Sawyer Island, which wasn't surprising since my arms were entirely useless. As I got up from my full-body dirt sprawl, grasping at the base of the mountain, I tried to act cool, like it was no big deal, while the kids still chortled.

I looked down at myself, and I saw three mud circles, one formed perfectly over each already wet boob, then a particularly large one that covered the spot where my big, fat belly is.

Well, I thought, at least I'm not naked anymore. I am emotionally destroyed and physically devastated, but I am no longer flashing.

I HATE DISNEYLAND.

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